

Throw Away Your Umbrella

September 10, 2026



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I. Throw Away Your Umbrella

Your Umbrella

- *Think about it right now.*

1

- Where did it come from?

2

- Where did you buy it?

3

- Is it even yours?

4

- Where is it right now?

BUT... like socks or a watch... it is part of you.

Use Cases

To You?



To Me?



II. Today

This Morning...

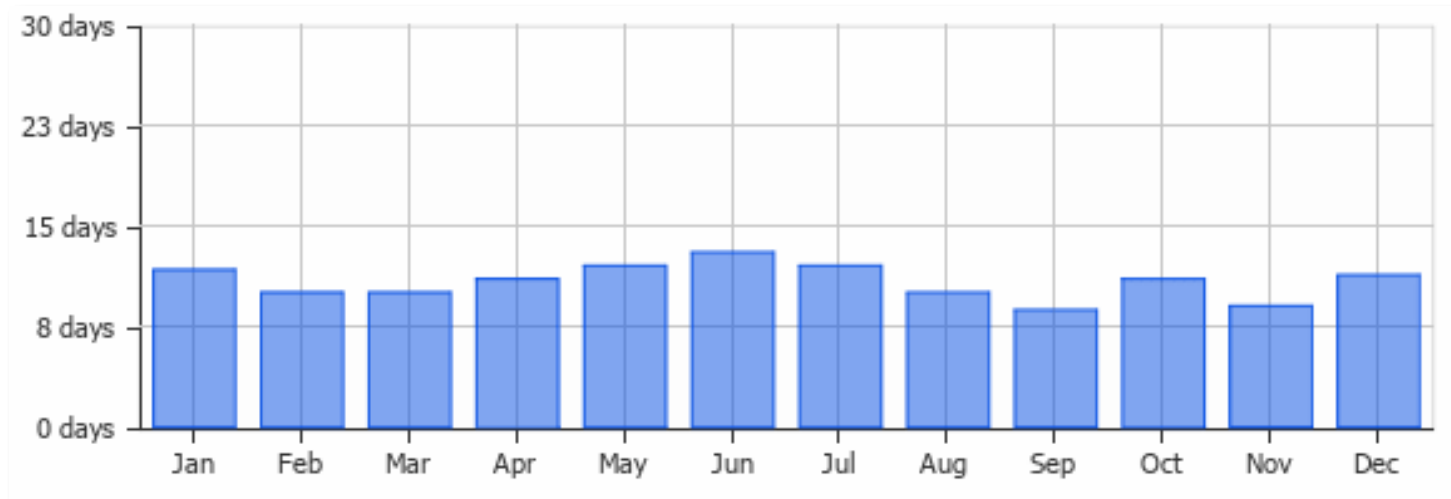


- The alarm sounds, you snooze it, you scroll
- Until eventually, a glimmer of light peaks through your window



OR...

- *No Light Comes.*
- *And you are left with a bone-chilling reality...*



TODAY is one of the ~125 days of the year that it RAINS in New York City.

So You Verify



- And with all of earth's knowledge at the tip of a button, you confirm: **Rain All Day.**



But Fear Not...



Because you are more prepared than any person in the history of civilization has been for the rain.

III. Centuries Ago

Pre-Modern Applications



- The modern application of the umbrella has only been around for about 300 years



- For millennia, umbrellas were used purely for sun protection – and a sign of status – making the modern usage of umbrellas not even that old



- **Jonas Hanway:** The Umbrella Visionary

Jonas Hanway: The Umbrella Visionary



- He arrived in London with an umbrella for rain protection and used it for 30 years
- He was ridiculed, often called “feminine” and “poor”
 - “Why can you not afford a carriage, Jonas?”
 - “Why is your character so weak, Jonas?”
- Cab drivers attacked him as they saw him a threat to their livelihood
- By his death in 1786 – after 3+ decades of attacks, the umbrella was widely popularized for secular use – with Hanway the posthumous face of the umbrella movement

IV. Millennia Ago

But There Was Life Before Hanway...



- For most of human history, rain was an inconvenience – it was a crisis – a life or death emergency

Picture This...

2000 BC



You Have One Directive... Find Shelter



- Find shelter, immediately – but without the conveniences of the 21st century

NOT Coming to Save you

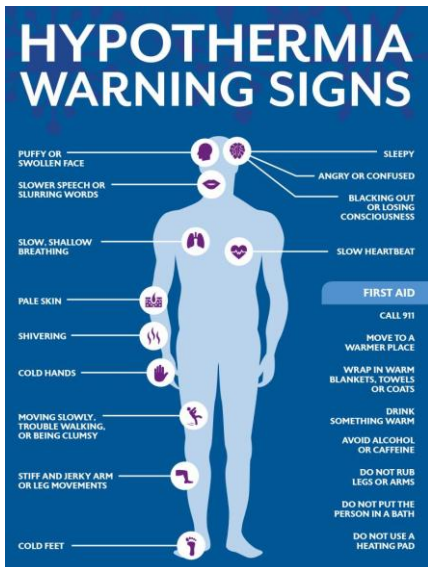


You Made It!

SAFETY

- Shelter has been found – that's only half the battle
- You now must fight imminent death on three fronts

Enemies



And All of this Happens without Warning

- *There were no apps, no weather channels, no way to know for certain what was coming*
- *They anticipated the weather, constantly*

1

- Watching the color and movement of the clouds

2

- Feeling the way the wind was shifting

3

- Observing animal behavior

4

- Seeing the other side of the leaves on the trees

They planned their entire lives around the rain.

Learning to Live with the Rain

- *They built shelters specifically designed to protect themselves from the rain*
- *They designed clothes that kept the rain from reaching their skin*
- *And lastly – they just accepted that getting wet was simply part of life*

Because...

- Just because it was thousands of years ago does not mean there was not an economy to upkeep
- There was no “waiting out” the storm – there was an entire economy of jobs to be done outdoors
- They didn’t “opt out” of the weather – they learned to live inside it



- Farmers



- Hunters



- Gatherers



- Militias



- Tradesmen



- Messengers

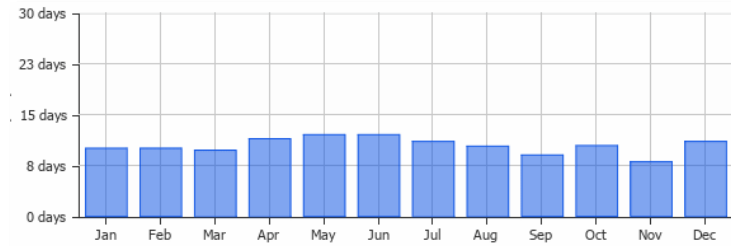


- Public Works

V. Why Die On This Hill?

It's a Great Question

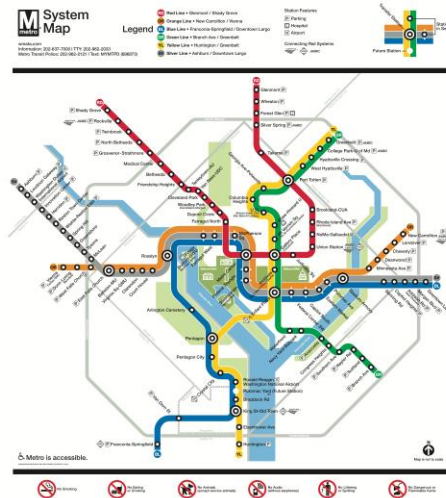
- *I used to hate the rain just as much as everyone else*
- *My first year in DC I was always caught in rainy days*
 - 118 per year, to be exact



4 Minutes



12 Minutes



8 Minutes

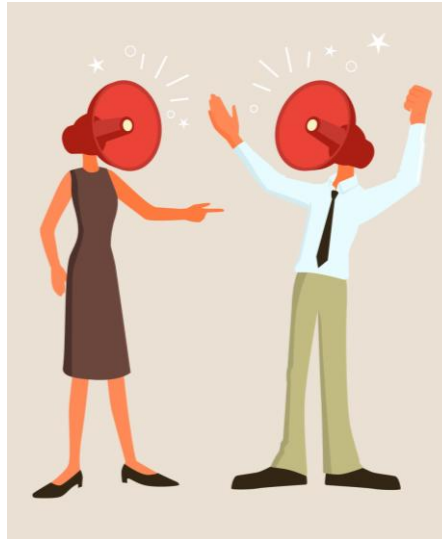


That Shifted My Mindset

10:00 AM



10:01 AM



10:13 AM



- *I was uncomfortable for 25 minutes – and I made a whole scene about it*
- *I then decided to never use an umbrella again*
- *And to the cab drivers in London making fun of Jonas Hanway? You guys were absolutely right.*



VI. Economic, Social, and Cultural Ramifications

What is the point?

Jobs

- *Rainfall and the subsequent life inside of a cave that came with it produced jobs and productions that didn't exist without it – some could call it the birthplace of specialization*
- *No one invents string out on the hunt; its invented sitting still, with time on your hands, waiting for it to pass*



Fire

- Keeping the fire going in a rain was crucial to survival – for light and warmth



String

- The oldest existence of string was found in a French cave from ~50,000 years ago



Bone Needles

- Found in caves across South Africa, Siberia, and China dating back 60,000 years

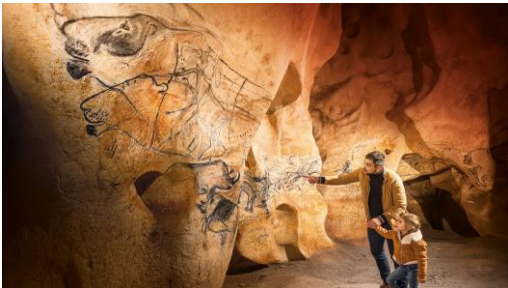
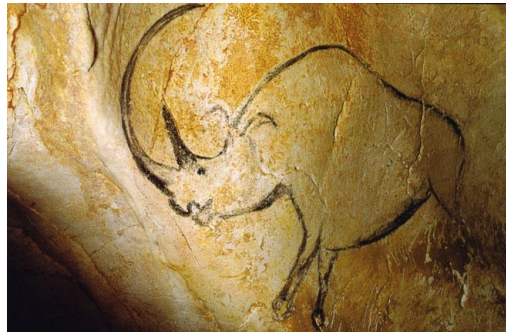


Bedding

- Perhaps the earliest existence of bedding – 200,000 years old – was recently discovered in a South African cave

Art

- *Deep in the Chauvet Cave in France can be found hundreds of renderings of 420+ species painted and engraved ~30,000 years ago*
- *The discovery reshaped the idea of how early art began as an activity / hobby*
- *Art was discovered hundreds of yards into the cave – assuming renderings were made from memory under periods of ample free time*
- *Implications: Rain didn't take away time, it gave time*



Culture



Rainfall gave communities an excuse to gather, tell stories, and create culture.

While there was an economy to upkeep, there was plenty of time for gathering and origin stories as well.



Why do the sea levels rise?



Why do the seasons change?



Why does the rain fall?

*Rain didn't take away time. It gave it to them.
So – what are we doing with the time we are given now?*

VII. Modern Day Implications

Rainfall Today

- *We treat rainfall the same way we treat boredom – as a discomfort that must immediately be quelled*
- *We can't be bored so we doomscroll – we can't be wet so we use an umbrella*
- *We are so addicted to comfort that the thought of being momentarily uncomfortable is alien*

Ancestors / Neanderthals



Us



Where is the purpose? The vision? The drive?

Case Study: Severance



- *The “Severance” procedure exists with the idea that individuals can elect to receive an operation that cuts off any form of suffering; the dentist, doing chores, even work*
- *But that is not life – you have to have “the bad” to appreciate “the good”*
- *How often does rain throw a wrench in our plans? How often do we cancel, postpone, or run late because of the rain?*
- *In New York, we get rain ~125 days a year – one third of the year!*
- *Are we to forgo our lives for those 125 days because of a minor inconvenience – one that has been dealt with for thousands of years before us?*

So... WHAT DO WE DO?!?

VIII. Takeaways

What to Do When it Rains?

- *We have the entire world's ecosystem at our fingertips*
- *Much like our ancestors did, let's use that for planning, not for excuses – don't rain-proof the day, design it in such a way that the rain doesn't even matter*

1

- Leave earlier – before the rain starts

2

- Splurge for the Uber

3

- Wear boots and a rain jacket and make a RUN for it

4

- Keep a towel in your bag and a pair of dry socks at your desk

5

- And then do whatever you were going to do anyway

And once you are finished!

- ***You can return to climate-controlled apartment***
- ***Where you can shower anytime you want, for as long as you want, at any temperature you so please***

A luxury not provided to the vast majority of human history

Things To Do

- ☒ *Get to the office and close some deals*
- ☒ *Get to the office and make some cold calls*
- ☒ *Get to the lecture that you paid good tuition money for*
- ☒ *Get to the coffee shop to catch up with your friend*
- ☒ *Go on that walk to call your mom*
- ☒ *Make it to the gym to set a PR*
- ☒ *Get to the train station to visit your family*
- ☒ *Get to the library to finish that pitch, screenplay, book, or blog post*
- ☒ *Get to where you need to go to do what you have been putting off doing*

Get Out There!

- *For majority of human history, a little bit of rain came with disastrous side effects – hypothermia, flooding, or becoming prey*
- *Appreciate that those will never happen to you*
- *Honor those that paved the way for you to live in comfort, and get a little uncomfortable*



IX. Drawing Conclusions

Objections

“Aidan, we’ve built all these tools to make our lives better – why shouldn’t we use them?”

- *Because you could make similar cases for a number of items...*

Rolling Suitcases? Just carry it.

Air Conditioning? Just sweat.

Coffee? Just wake up.

Portable Chargers? Just wait.

Just pick one.

Pick One

Just pick one.

For me, it's umbrellas.

- I think they're clumsy, dangerous, and flimsy.
- I think they make me look like I'm not tough.
- They take up too much space on the sidewalk and hit me in the face when I'm on it.
- They're embarrassing, they're not biodegradable, they're not fashionable.

And by not using them, I'm handed time. Free time.

Time with which I have to be intentional, with which I refuse to waste – because I am aware of the economic, social, and cultural implications of rain throughout history.

I plan, I schedule, I coordinate – I know an umbrella will not be there to keep me dry, so I plan my life around making things happen in its absence.

I'd implore you to do the same.

- Maybe it's umbrellas. Maybe it's not. Maybe you always use Apple Maps and instead try making it to your reservations using the street signs.
- Pick something that is making your life easier, and eliminate it. Don't play on rookie mode anymore.
- Growth doesn't happen in the comfort zone – it happens in the 25 minutes you spend drying off from your commute.

It is Supposed to Be Inconvenient

If there were umbrellas...



Then there would have been no bedding
discovered in that South African cave

If there were umbrellas...



Then there would have been no artwork
discovered deep in the Chauvet Cave

If there were umbrellas...



There would have been no 50,000-year-
old string

If there were umbrellas...



Or primordial bone needles

If there were umbrellas...



Or stories of why the seasons change,
the tide rises, and the rain falls

Therefore, I will continue to forgo using one, so that I can add to this list.
It won't happen from my couch.

So throw away your umbrella.